

RITIK KHANTWAL



FIELD GUIDE 05

The Office Lunch Guide

Canteen, Swiggy, dabba or client lunch — how to order and assemble a 500-calorie, 35g-protein meal anywhere, in under 60 seconds of thinking.

Ritik Khantwal

Fitness & performance for Indian professionals

Edition 2026

Lunch is where the day is decided

A heavy rice-and-curry canteen plate is the reason you're useless from 2:30 to 4pm and raiding the vending machine by 5. Fix lunch and you fix the afternoon, the evening craving and the late dinner.

You don't need to bring a dabba every day or eat salads. You need one repeatable decision framework that works whether you're in a Gurgaon canteen, ordering on Swiggy, or sitting in a client's boardroom.

THE FRAMEWORK

Protein first. Vegetables second. Carbs last and capped. Physically build the plate in that order — protein and salad go on before rice or roti. You'll eat roughly 30% fewer carbs without ever deciding to.

What a good office lunch looks like

Component	Amount	Example
Protein	Palm-sized × 1.5	150 g chicken, 100 g paneer, 1.5 katori rajma, 2 eggs + dal
Vegetables	Two fists	Dry sabzi, salad, sauteed greens, raita
Carbs	One cupped hand	1 katori rice OR 2 rotis. Not both, not unlimited.
Fat	One thumb	Already in the gravy. Don't add ghee on top.

That's roughly **500–600 calories and 35–40 g protein**. Enough to be full until 5pm. Light enough to think clearly at 3pm.

The canteen decision tree

Non-vegetarian counter

- **Best:** tandoori/grilled chicken, egg curry, fish curry, chicken tikka, boiled egg add-on
- **Fine:** chicken curry (drain the top layer of oil), keema, chicken biryani — but take one serving of rice, not two
- **Skip:** fried chicken, butter chicken as a daily choice, anything labelled "malai" or "shahi"

Vegetarian counter

- **Best:** paneer tikka, rajma, chana masala, dal (take two servings, not one), curd, soya chunks
- **Fine:** paneer butter masala — take the paneer, leave most of the gravy
- **Skip:** aloo-anything as the main protein (it isn't one), puri, fried snacks, sweetened lassi

The upgrade rules

Instead of	Take	Difference
2 katori rice	1 katori rice + extra dal	−150 kcal, +8 g protein
Butter naan	2 tandoori roti	−200 kcal
Fried papad	Roasted papad or salad	−60 kcal
Sweet lassi	Plain chaas or curd	−180 kcal, same satisfaction
Gulab jamun	Fruit, or share one piece	−250 kcal
Aloo sabzi	Any dal or paneer sabzi	+10 g protein

THE TWO-PLATE TRAP

Take one plate and sit down. Going back for a second round is almost always boredom or conversation, not hunger. If you're genuinely still hungry after 15 minutes, go back for protein and salad only.

Ordering in, and eating out

Swiggy / Zomato: the safe list

Cuisine	Order this	Not this
North Indian	Tandoori chicken / paneer tikka + 2 roti + dal	Butter chicken + naan + biryani combo
South Indian	2 idli + sambar + omelette on the side	Masala dosa + vada + filter coffee with sugar
Chinese	Chicken/paneer in dry or hot-garlic style + steamed rice	Fried rice + Manchurian + Manchow combo
Bowls / salads	Grilled protein bowl, dressing on the side	"Healthy" bowls with mayo, cheese and 3 sauces
Biryani	Half plate + extra raita + salad	Full plate + gravy + coke

Three ordering rules

- **Order for one.** Combos exist to make you buy more food than you need. Skip the combo, order two items.
- **Add a protein side always.** Two boiled eggs, extra dal, a portion of curd — costs ₹40, changes the whole meal.
- **Order before you're starving.** Ordering at 2:15pm on an empty stomach is how the fries get added.

The client lunch

You can't control the venue and shouldn't be visibly dieting at the table. Three moves that are invisible to everyone else:

- Order a protein-led main. Grilled fish, tandoori platter, kebabs.
- Take bread once when the basket comes around, then let it pass.
- Order sparkling or plain water immediately. It occupies the hand that would otherwise be reaching.

The 20-minute Sunday dabba prep

If you want the easy mode: cook one protein and one sabzi in bulk on Sunday. Chicken or rajma, plus one dry sabzi. Portion into four boxes. Add fresh roti or rice each morning. That's four of five weekdays solved for 20 minutes of work.

- ☐ One protein cooked in bulk
- ☐ One dry sabzi cooked in bulk
- ☐ Four containers portioned and stacked
- ☐ Curd, fruit and roasted chana stocked at the desk

The 3pm test

You'll know lunch was right by how you feel at 3pm. Sharp and not hungry means you got it. Foggy and reaching for chai means it was too heavy on carbs and too light on protein. Adjust tomorrow.